purposes. Indeed, these very issues are now central to the priorities of Indian diplomacy. We strive to ensure better access to our talent, stronger protection for our workers, greater opportunities for our students and fairer markets for our businesses.

But the world is not simply about mobility and migration. It is as much about partnerships, compacts and understandings that serve all parties well. In fact, a deeper engagement could lead to accelerating our national development, exploring more markets, procuring resources, improving our quality of life, expanding employment and, not least, shaping crucial global issues that determine the future of our planet.

To accurately assess what the world means to us, we must first of all appreciate that the globalized era in which we live is very much a double-edged existence. It is hard to separate the vulnerabilities from the dependence or the risks from the benefits. The very mobility that brought Covid to our homes was otherwise such an enormous source of livelihood for so many. The supply chains, which created disruption when they did not function, were a veritable boon when they actually did. Their complexity may be now hard to describe, as indeed their salience to critical aspects of our life. But the Covid era showed us how much we were all dependent on the cross-border flows of goods and services.

Not surprisingly, India was both a contributor and beneficiary in that regard. We sent out shipments of vaccines to almost a hundred nations. But we received ingredients from many of them as well. Nations in the Gulf were critically dependent on Indian exports for their daily consumption. And that continued without interruption because there was a deep understanding of this requirement. This paid off during the medical oxygen crisis in 2021, when the same countries cited it to make shipments to us.

Indeed, if there is one big lesson for the globalized economy from the Covid experience, it is that of more capabilities and options. The ‘just-in-time’ approach with its concentration in a limited geography showed how vulnerable the world could be in a crisis. De-risking the world economy now requires a ‘just-in-case’ outlook with more diversified production. Where India is concerned, this could mean another chance to board the bus of manufacturing that we had missed a few times before. And this is exactly what the ‘ease-of-doing-business’ approach and the offer of ‘production-linked incentives’ are intended to ensure.